



BUDDHADEB (RIGHT) FOLLOWED THE CENTRE'S DIKTAT BUT ALSO HAD TO KEEP PARTY BOSSES HAPPY

that security personnel get demoralised and frustrated when asked to get into the no-win situation. Five years after Manmohan Singh termed Left extremism as the biggest threat to the country, the Government is yet to come out with a cohesive policy which experts say would be far better option to deal with such a threat than a ban.

According to former Intelligence Bureau chief Ajit Doval, bans were an effective tool, provided there was an element of surprise. Before proscribing an outfit, he said that due diligence had to be exercised with adequate operational intelligence and sufficient evidence to act against the group as soon as the ban was announced. "The aim of the ban should be to systematically target what nurtures the organisation—funds, recruits, weapons and ideology. All the four fronts need to be tackled and the crackdown has to be quick. Otherwise, some operatives will go underground, evidence will disappear and financiers will become careful as soon as the ban comes into place," he explained, adding that the law and order aspect of the problem could be dealt with ordinary laws of the Indian Penal Code (IPC). It is the additionalities like funding, recruits and ideology which needed the special provisions of the UAPA. Besides, some substantial action should already have been taken against the Maoists to justify and follow up on the ban, which in this case does not appear to have been done.

With the lack of determined political will, most of the bans have not worked as effectively as the Government would have liked. The ban on SIMI failed miserably with all its members going underground. While they were overground, at least their activities were in public domain and could be monitored. If the intelligence agencies of the country were equipped to

Law Amendment Act. But political posturing apart, sources in security agencies said that the ban on Maoists was unlikely to give much of an additional advantage in real terms. "It's more psychological than anything. It's just another way to put pressure on the organisation, its members and the state Government," claimed an official. CPI (Maoists) was an amorphous group and most of the members were already underground. "How does one implement the ban? How do security agencies act against it," he asked.

As proof, the officials point to the ban on 34 other outfits earlier, saying that nothing much had been achieved. The ULFA is still active. The LET and JEM are still out there. The SIMI is still supporting the sleeper cells of jihadi militant outfits. The CPI (Marxist-Leninist), People's War Group, and Maoist Communist Centre (MCC), with

all their formations and front organisations, were already on the banned list. "The ban has not stopped Naxals from increasing their influence and intensity of violence. Despite the previous ban, the Centre was forced to include CPI (Maoists) individually in the list," mocked a senior official involved in combating Left wing extremism.

A ban would be effective only if it was backed by political will, reliable intelligence inputs and concerted action by security forces like the determined Sri Lankan operations against LTTE chief Prabhakaran. While the Left opposed the ban on Maoists, other political parties like the Samajwadi Party, Rashtriya Janata Dal and Loktantrik Janata Party had vehemently opposed the ban on SIMI. "As long as these outfits keep getting political backing, no bans would ever be effective," said an official, adding